

Université SAAD DAHLEB - BLIDA

Medical instrumentation Project

Biomedical Engineering Degree

“Visual Neuroprosthesis: Transcribing the Language of Light”

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Author: Mohamed Habak

Director/s: Dr. Yazid Cherfa

Abstract

The concept of restoring vision to the blind has always been considered beyond human reach—something associated with folklore, science fiction, or divine intervention. And yet, the human spirit remains undeterred. Through great scientific effort, we are walking the path to a future where no one is denied the gift of light.

This paper reviews the current advancements and challenges in visual neuroprosthetics, evaluating both the underlying technologies and clinical trial outcomes. These devices trick the brain into thinking it can see what an external receptor, such as a camera, detects. By carefully stimulating parts of the visual system with precise electrical signals, they generate artificial visual images, allowing blind individuals to perceive shapes and movement.

As human trials continue to refine this technology, several critical challenges remain: How can we determine when visual neuroprosthetics are appropriate for a patient? How can long-term performance and effectiveness be objectively measured and optimized? And what strategies are most effective for rehabilitating implanted patients to achieve functional, meaningful vision?

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I. Introduction

Vision is more than just a sense; it is the window through which we experience life, making its loss a challenge that touches every facet of human existence. Vision impairment (VI) can result from various factors, including injury, infections, age-related degeneration, genetic disorders, and neurological conditions. While mild and moderate cases of VI can often be corrected or improved with corrective lenses or surgical procedures, severe VI and blindness are often irreversible, requiring alternative strategies for adaptation rather than full restoration through conventional methods.

The International Classification of Diseases, 10th revision (ICD-10) categorizes VI into four levels: mild or no VI, moderate VI, severe VI, and blindness. These classifications are based on visual acuity (the clarity or sharpness of vision). Since severe VI and blindness currently have no complete cure, visual Neuroprosthetics represent a promising technological intervention for these cases. These devices aim to restore partial functional vision by bypassing damaged retinal or neural pathways.

Vision loss may occur suddenly, such as in cases of trauma or retinal detachment, or gradually, as seen in conditions like macular degeneration and glaucoma. This diversity in causes highlights the complexity of vision impairment and underscores the urgent need for innovative solutions.

In response to this need, this paper examines the innovative field of visual Neuroprosthetics—an advanced form of prosthetics designed to restore vision by merging technology with the human body. The primary objective is to understand the mechanics by which this technology works, assess its potential benefits and current limitations, determine suitable candidates for its use, and identify promising future directions in research and development

II. How Visual Neuroprosthetics Work

Bionic eyes are a form of neuroprosthetics that are designed to partially restore vision in individuals suffering from severe vision loss. Unlike other treatments for vision impairment that focus on repairing the natural eye through corrective lenses or surgeries, bionic eyes completely bypass the damaged visual pathways and directly stimulate the section of the brain responsible for vision to create artificial vision.

When using this technology, instead of treating the damaged neuronal elements that make up the visual pathway, we create a completely new mechanism by which the patient perceives light. Using an array of tiny microelectrodes, we can send electrical signals directly to the remaining visual neurons, tricking the patient's brain into seeing discrete points of light (phosphenes). By stimulating multiple locations in the cortex in a controlled way, we can create patterns using these points of light that resemble actual shapes instead of dots.

The way the brain perceives these artificial images is similar to how an inkjet printer works; each dot of light (phosphene) acts like a droplet of ink or pixel, and when all these dots are combined, they form a larger, meaningful picture. However, with current technology, we are only able to simulate shapes and objects, not true natural sight with colors, depth, or texture.

Because the retina and visual pathways are arranged in a map-like way—meaning that specific areas correspond to different parts of the visual field—it is essential that the microelectrodes are correctly placed and that signals are sent exactly to the areas corresponding to the desired part of the visual field. This makes the entire procedure a very delicate process requiring microscopic precision.

The pattern by which we spread the phosphenes is determined by analyzing an image captured by an external receptor, such as a camera, and then processing and converting it into electrical signals that are sent to the necessary parts of the visual system (see figure 1).

Given the extremely complex nature of the human brain, the process by which it translates electrical signals into actual sight is equally complex. Rather than attempting to recreate every detail of the natural process artificially, it is more efficient to use the parts of the visual system that remain functional to take on most of the signal processing.

Following this logic, if the retina (the light-sensitive layer at the back of the eye) is still functional, it becomes the ideal site for implanting the prosthetic because it is the first step in vision processing. By stimulating the retina instead of deeper brain areas, we can use its existing connections to send signals naturally to the brain.

Retinitis pigmentosa (RP) and age-related macular degeneration (AMD) are disorders that affect the retina. RP causes progressive vision loss and eventual blindness, while AMD, which primarily affects the elderly, leads to vision loss in the central portion of the visual field. Both disorders mainly target the light-capturing component of the outer segment of the retina (photoreceptor cells). However, other retinal cells, such as bipolar and ganglion cells, often survive and continue sending visual information to the brain through the optic nerve.

A retinal prosthetic bypasses these dead photoreceptors by directly stimulating the retina's surviving nerve cells to send signals to the brain. Researchers tested this approach by applying electrical stimulation to the retinas of RP and AMD patients who had been blind for years, and the patients reported seeing phosphenes. Although the images were basic and unclear at first, by adjusting the position and number of electrodes, as well as the strength and timing of the electrical pulses, the shapes and patterns of light seen by the patients could be changed. These results proved that a retinal prosthesis can be more than just a proof of concept, prompting many groups worldwide to pursue retinal implants as one of the most researched approaches to restoring vision, with numerous clinical trials testing different designs.

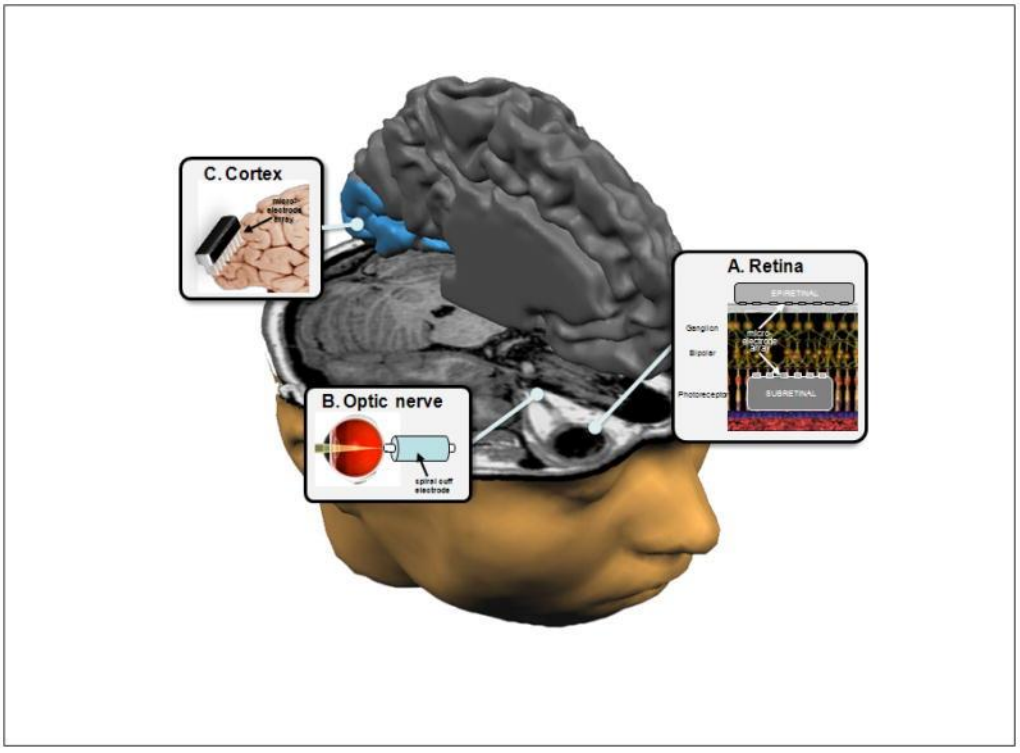


Figure 1 (The visual pathway).

1. General Function of Visual Neuroprosthetics

This section explains the overall principle common to all visual neuroprosthetics, not just retinal implants. The process begins with capturing an image using an external receptor (for example, a camera). The image is processed into electrical signals that are then transmitted through an array of microelectrodes to the remaining functional neurons within the visual system. These signals generate discrete phosphenes, which when arranged properly, form a recognizable image. The system's success relies heavily on the mapping of the visual field and the microscopic precision in electrode placement to stimulate the correct areas.

2. Retinal Implants

When the retina retains partial function, it offers the most natural starting point for restoring vision. Retinal implants take advantage of the fact that even though the photoreceptor cells may be lost, other cells (like bipolar and ganglion cells) remain capable of transmitting visual information to the brain. There are two main strategies: sub-retinal and epi-retinal implants.

a. Sub-Retinal Implants

Sub-retinal implants are placed beneath the retina, specifically between the sensory retina (from the nerve fiber layer to the photoreceptor outer segments) and the retinal pigment epithelium (RPE)—the space once occupied by dead photoreceptor cells (see figure 2 to understand the structure of the retina). This strategy directly targets the surviving bipolar cells to utilize the retina's natural neural connections.

- **Mechanism and Testing:**
  A retinal prosthetic bypasses dead photoreceptors and stimulates the surviving nerve cells. Tests involving RP and AMD patients, who had been blind for years, showed that electrical stimulation produced phosphenes. Adjusting the position, number of electrodes, and the timing and strength of the electrical pulse allowed modification of the shapes and patterns of light.
- **Surgical Approach and Projects:**
  The Boston Retinal Implant Project—a collaboration between Harvard Medical School, MIT, Massachusetts Eye and Ear Infirmary, Boston VA Healthcare System, and others—employs an "ab externo" approach. An incision in the sclera creates a small space between the sensory retina and the RPE. Here, an ultra-thin, flexible microelectrode array is inserted without cutting through the retina, while the primary electronic components are sealed in a titanium case outside the eye. This method minimizes retinal damage and reduces risks such as heat buildup and corrosion.
- **Alternative Designs:**
  The Artificial Silicone Retina (ASR) from Optobionics Corporation is another sub-retinal implant that uses around 5000 micro-photodiodes, each paired with its own stimulating electrode. After implantation under the retina, the photodiodes capture light and convert it into an electrical current that stimulates nearby retinal neurons. In clinical trials with RP patients, the ASR showed improvements in visual field and letter recognition. It is important to note that the ASR might also induce a neurotrophic ("cell rescue") effect, potentially slowing retinal degeneration. Additionally, a German research team (Retina Implant AG) is developing a sub-retinal implant with signal amplification to produce more stable visual perceptions, with early trials showing promising results.

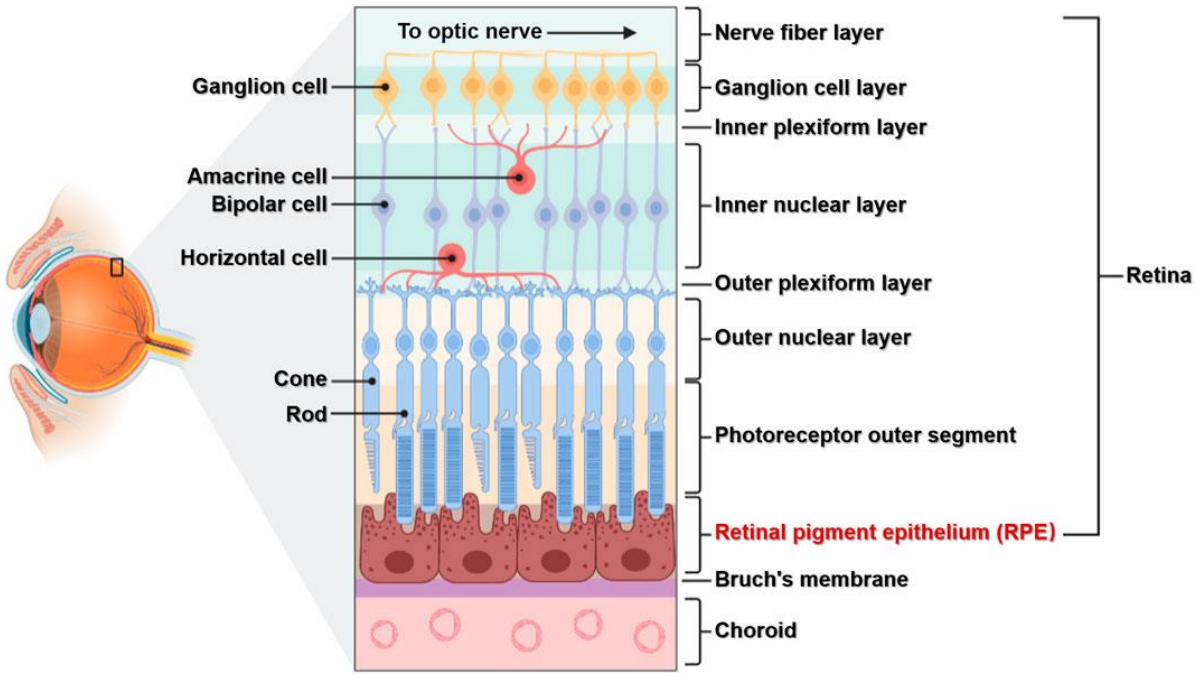


Figure 2 (structure of the retina).

b. Epi-Retinal Implants

Epi-retinal implants are placed directly on the inner surface of the retina and are designed to stimulate ganglion cells—the final layer of neurons that convey visual information to the brain. This approach is especially useful in conditions like RP, where photoreceptors and bipolar cells are severely compromised.

- **Mechanism and Process:**
  By targeting ganglion cells directly, epi-retinal implants bypass earlier visual processing stages. The Artificial Retina Project—a collaboration between the Doheny Eye Institute (University of Southern California) and Second Sight Medical Products—exemplifies this approach. The procedure begins with a sclerotomy, which involves making tiny incisions in the sclera to access the vitreous humor. A vitrectomy is performed to remove the vitreous gel that could obstruct access to the retina.
- **Surgical Details and Device Operation:**
  Once the retina is exposed, a thin, flexible microelectrode array is carefully positioned on the retinal surface and secured with small metallic pins known as Retinal Tacks. A fine wire extends from the array, exiting the eye through a small incision to connect with an external processing unit. A camera mounted on eyeglasses captures images, converts them into electrical signals, and transmits these signals to the implant. This setup enables the patient to perceive basic light patterns and shapes.
  Two major devices developed under this method include:
  1. **Argus I:** A prototype with 16 electrodes that has been successfully tested in human trials.
  2. **Argus II:** A more advanced version with 60 electrodes, currently undergoing large-scale clinical trials. Studies with Argus II show that patients can detect flashes of light, distinguish simple shapes, and exhibit improved spatial accuracy in visual-motor tasks.

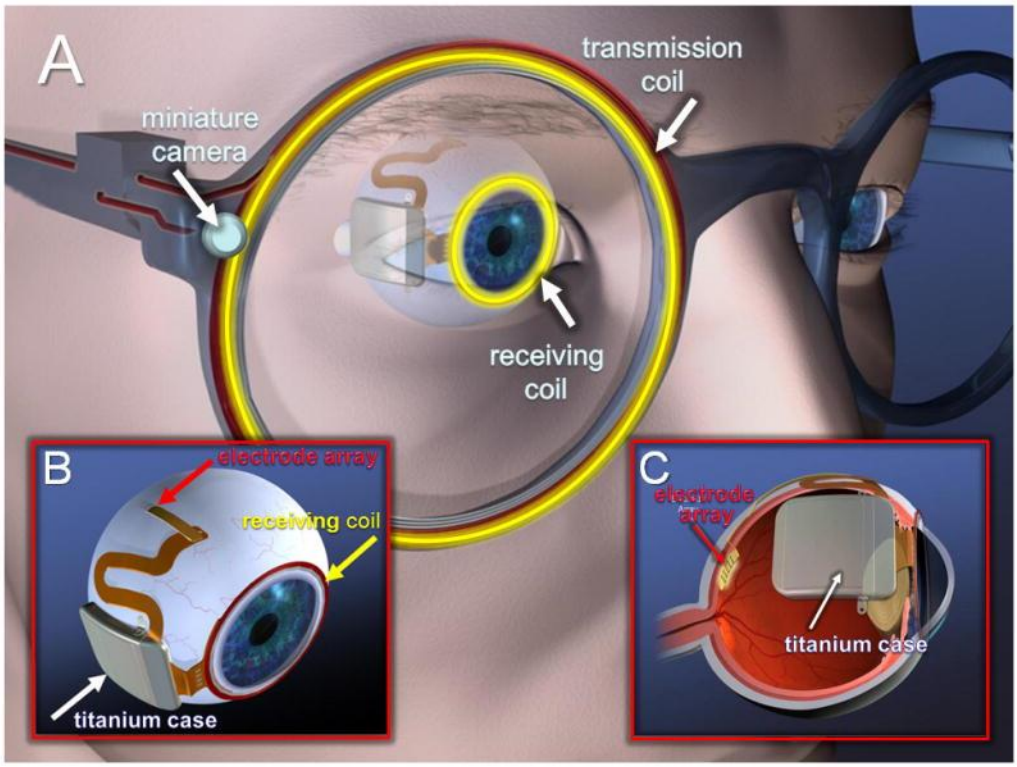


Figure 3 (Artist's conception of the Boston Retinal Implant device)

3. Optic Nerve Implants

When the retina is too damaged to function, the next viable target for visual restoration is the optic nerve. One approach, developed by a Belgian consortium, involves a cuff electrode–a small ring-shaped device that wraps around the optic nerve. This electrode delivers controlled electrical pulses to the nerve fibers, simulating the natural signals produced by a healthy retina. Visual information, captured by an external camera and processed into stimulation patterns, is transmitted along the optic nerve to the visual cortex. Early trials indicate that patients can perceive phosphenes and, with training, may learn to recognize simple shapes, lines, and even letters.

4. Cortical Implants

If both the retina and the optic nerve are completely non-functional, the only remaining target for visual prostheses is the brain itself. Cortical implants work by directly stimulating the visual cortex–the area of the brain responsible for processing vision–thereby bypassing both the eye and the optic nerve.

- **Mechanism:**
  Electrode arrays implanted on or within the visual cortex generate phosphenes corresponding to different regions of the visual field. This direct stimulation provides a potential solution for nearly all forms of blindness.
- **Challenges:**
  Although early research has demonstrated that electrical stimulation of the visual cortex can produce basic light perceptions, significant challenges remain. These include developing effective methods to encode complex visual information, ensuring long-term implant stability, and minimizing the risks associated with brain surgery.

III. Challenges and limitations

The development of visual neuroprosthetic devices requires extensive collaboration between scientists, engineers, and clinicians. While significant technical progress has been made, several key challenges must be overcome before these implants can be widely adopted as clinical treatments.

I. Electrode Geometry and Neural Stimulation Challenges

One of the primary challenges in visual prostheses is the geometry of the implanted electrodes, which directly affects the resolution of perceived images. Electrodes placed closer together have the potential to provide higher-resolution visual perceptions. However, several factors limit this spacing:

- **Electrical Interference:** Closely spaced electrodes may cause unintended current spread, leading to overlapping neural stimulation and reduced clarity in the generated visual perception.
- **Physical Size Constraints:** Electrodes must be small enough to fit within the retinal or cortical environment without causing mechanical damage.
- **Current Control:** Delivering appropriate current levels is crucial to avoid overstimulation, which could lead to neuronal damage or unpredictable visual distortions over time.

Over extended periods of use, the long-term effects of continuous electrical stimulation on degenerating retinal or cortical neurons remain uncertain. Researchers are addressing these concerns by exploring novel electrode designs and materials.

One promising approach is the development of **pillar electrode arrays**, which feature microstructures that penetrate neural tissue, bringing neurons into closer proximity with the electrodes. This design reduces the required stimulation current, lowering the risk of tissue damage and improving signal clarity. However, ensuring the long-term biocompatibility of these electrodes remains an ongoing challenge.

II. Image Alignment and Eye Movement Coordination

Another major hurdle in the functionality of visual neuroprosthetics is the misalignment between visual input and natural eye movements. In individuals with normal vision, the brain seamlessly integrates retinal signals with eye movement to maintain a stable perception of the environment. However, in prosthetic systems—particularly those using an **externally mounted camera**—this coordination is disrupted.

When the camera remains fixed while the eyes move, the brain receives conflicting information, leading to perceptual mismatches such as image instability or object misalignment. This issue is particularly pronounced in camera-based prostheses, where the natural oculomotor response does not automatically adjust the perceived image.

To mitigate this problem, researchers are developing **real-time eye-tracking systems** that detect and compensate for eye movements by dynamically adjusting visual input. While this technology is still in development, preliminary studies suggest that patients can learn to compensate for these discrepancies over time by adjusting their head and camera positioning. Training programs designed to help users adapt to these visual shifts may play a crucial role in improving the functionality of visual prostheses.

III. Candidate Selection and Implant Placement

Not all blind individuals are suitable candidates for a visual prosthesis, and careful patient selection is essential for ensuring implant success. Several clinical diagnostic tools are employed to assess a patient's visual impairment and predict their responsiveness to neurostimulation:

- **Electroretinogram (ERG):** Measures retinal electrical activity in response to light stimuli.
- **Visual Evoked Potentials (VEPs):** Assesses brain responses to visual stimuli.
- **Visual Field Perimetry:** Maps the remaining functional visual field to determine the extent of vision loss.

IV. Predictive Testing for Implant Success

Researchers have developed preoperative predictive tests to determine which patients are most likely to benefit from an implant. One critical factor is the **stimulation threshold**, which refers to the minimum electrical current needed to evoke a visual perception. Lower current thresholds are desirable as they reduce energy demands and minimize potential tissue damage.

Key predictive tests include:

- **Dark-adapted bright flash and flicker electroretinograms:** Assess retinal function under different lighting conditions.
- **Electrical evoked responses:** Evaluate the responsiveness of neural pathways to electrical stimulation, helping to predict the effectiveness of a prosthetic device.

V. Imaging Techniques for Optimized Implant Placement

Advanced imaging methods help researchers and clinicians determine the best placement for visual prostheses by assessing structural and functional integrity:

- **Functional MRI (fMRI) and Diffusion Tensor Imaging (DTI):** Evaluate the activity and connectivity of the visual cortex to determine suitable implant locations for cortical prostheses.
- **Optical Coherence Tomography (OCT):** Provides high-resolution images of retinal layers, helping to identify areas with the highest potential for stimulation response (see figure 4).

These imaging techniques are particularly valuable for understanding **disease progression** in retinal degeneration. As retinal cells reorganize over time, the timing of implantation becomes a crucial factor—early intervention may preserve residual function and improve outcomes.

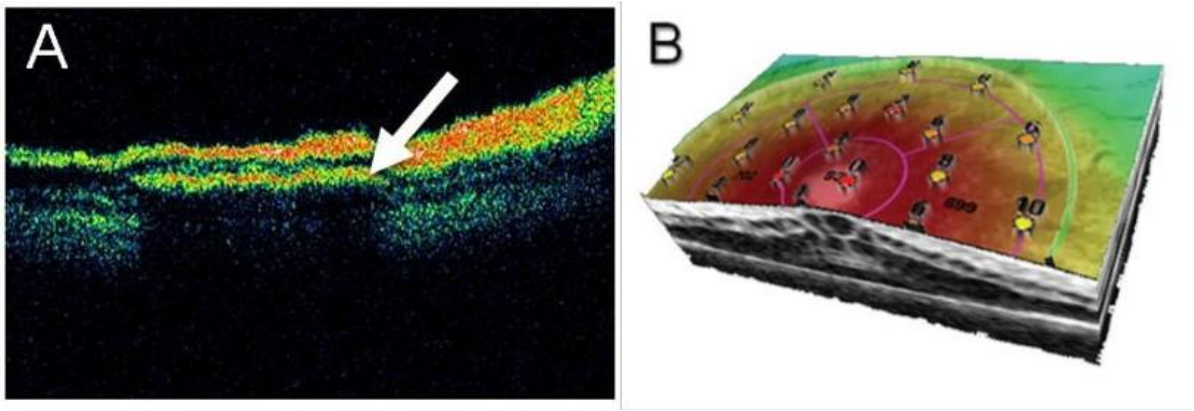


Figure 4 (Advanced imaging technology used to help with implant positioning and retinal integrity.)

IV. Future Perspectives

Research on visual neuroprosthetics has demonstrated that patterned electrical stimulation can evoke light perceptions, proving the feasibility of these devices. However, as clinical trials expand, the focus must shift from proof-of-concept to assessing the real-world impact on patients' quality of life. The success of these devices should not be judged solely on their technical performance but on their ability to enhance daily living, such as object recognition, navigation, and functional independence. Standardized assessment protocols are essential to measure device efficacy in a scientifically verifiable manner. Additionally, clearer selection criteria for candidates would facilitate comparison across studies and ensure realistic patient expectations.

A key challenge in patient adaptation is the mismatch between expected and actual visual percepts. Early trials have shown that the perceived images often do not correspond directly to the stimulation patterns, highlighting limitations in the "scoreboard approach" of retinal stimulation. This issue may stem from the degeneration of neural tissue, which affects how electrical signals are processed. While technical advancements will improve perceptual quality, a fundamental barrier remains—understanding how to introduce meaningful visual information to the brain. Simply increasing resolution or electrode count may not be sufficient, as higher-resolution images may initially lack interpretability for the patient.

Neuroplasticity plays a significant role in visual restoration. Studies indicate that the brain undergoes profound reorganization after vision loss, particularly in the occipital cortex. The extent of these changes varies based on the cause, onset, and duration of blindness. Understanding these neuroplastic constraints is crucial for improving rehabilitative strategies. Successful adaptation to a neuroprosthetic device requires structured training programs that help patients integrate artificial vision with other sensory inputs, such as touch and sound, to form coherent percepts. Sensory-substitution research could provide valuable insights into this process.

Future advancements may involve patient-controlled systems that align prosthetic vision with other sensory inputs, enabling more intuitive object recognition. Training programs should be designed to help patients actively interpret new visual information, rather than relying on spontaneous adaptation. Additionally, any visual prosthesis must complement existing rehabilitation strategies, such as mobility aids, without disrupting their benefits. Ultimately, the goal is to ensure that visual neuroprosthetics provide meaningful improvements over current assistive technologies, enhancing independence and quality of life for blind individuals.

V. Conclusion

Throughout this thesis, we have examined the promise and challenges of visual neuroprostheses as a means to restore some degree of sight to individuals living with severe vision loss. We began by outlining how these devices—from sub-retinal and epi-retinal implants to optic nerve and cortical arrays—bypass damaged photoreceptors or neural pathways to elicit phosphenes, thereby creating the perception of light and rudimentary shapes.

Our review of clinical and engineering advances highlights that, while early devices such as the Argus II and the Artificial Silicone Retina have successfully enabled blind patients to detect simple patterns and navigate basic environments, significant hurdles remain. Electrode geometry must be refined to increase resolution without causing unwanted current spread; image alignment systems need to keep pace with natural eye movements; and patient selection protocols—using ERG, VEP, and advanced imaging like OCT and fMRI—must become more precise to identify those most likely to benefit.

Looking ahead, the real measure of success for visual neuroprosthetics lies not only in technological milestones but also in meaningful improvements to daily life. Future research should prioritize:

1. **Neuroplasticity-informed rehabilitation**, by developing structured training programs that integrate artificial vision with residual senses, facilitating the brain's adaptation to new visual inputs.
2. **Patient-controlled systems**, enabling users to adjust stimulation parameters and sensory alignment in real time, fostering greater comfort and functional gains.
3. **Standardized assessment protocols**, so that outcomes—ranging from object recognition accuracy to quality-of-life metrics—can be compared across studies and devices.
4. **Long-term safety and biocompatibility studies**, ensuring that novel electrode materials and architectures remain effective and non-detrimental over years of use.

Ultimately, visual neuroprosthetics stand at the intersection of engineering innovation, neuroscience, and clinical care. By combining ever-improving hardware with a deeper understanding of how the blind brain reorganizes itself after sight loss, we move closer to a future where no one is denied the gift of vision. Continued interdisciplinary collaboration, patient-centered design, and rigorous evaluation will be essential to translate these laboratory successes into real-world solutions, ensuring that no one is denied the chance to see again.

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